

A better relationship between the mapping community and data consumers

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State of the Map Europe 2025

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The OSM do-ocracy

The synergy between mapping and the use of data lies at the heart of OpenStreetMap but relations have not always been as good as they ought to be. This talk examines how communication between mappers and data consumers can be improved.

Trust in OSM

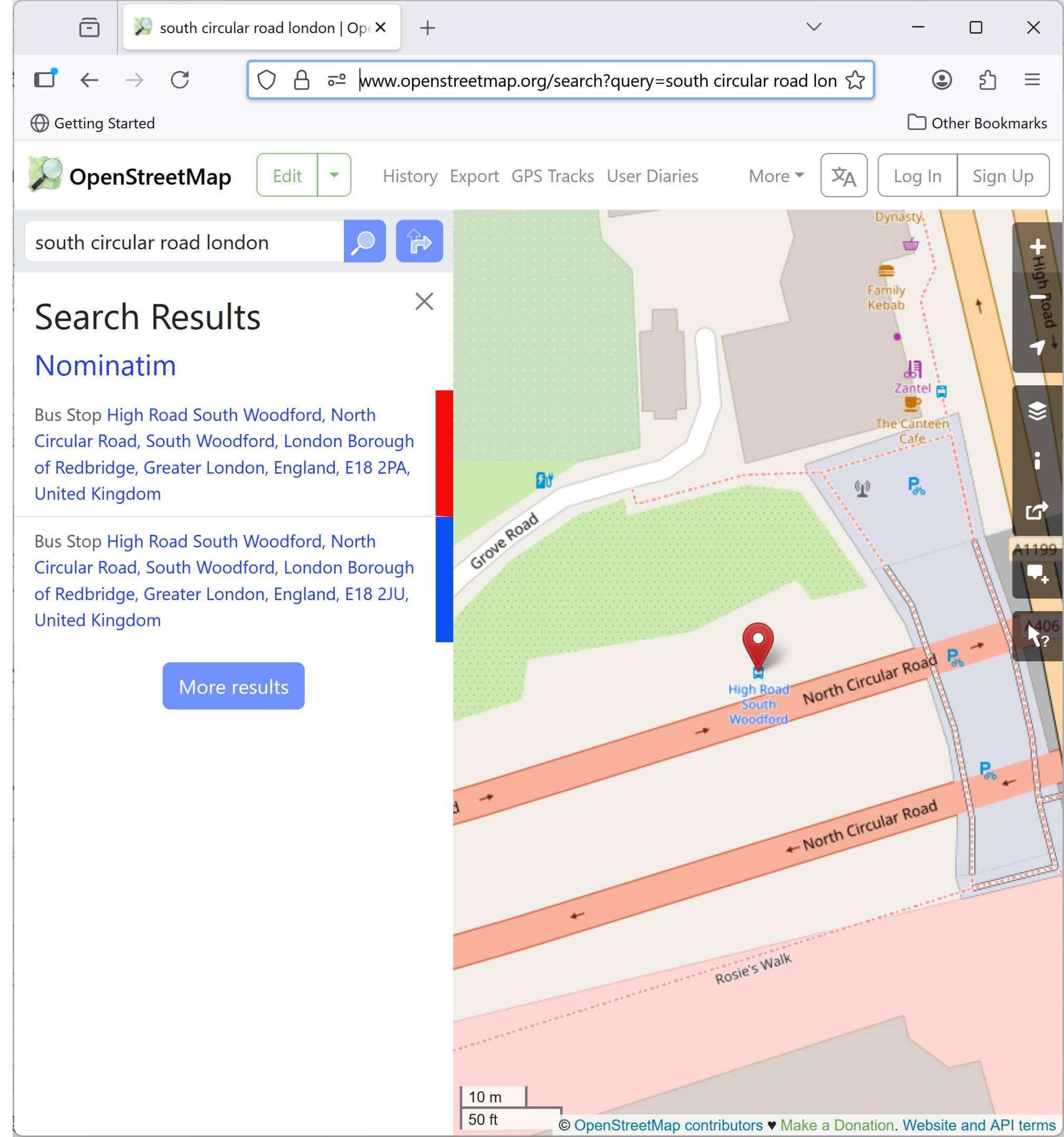
- The ecosystem in OpenStreetMap is built on trust between our contributors.
- Communication within the community is central to its success.
- OSM has always been a vehicle for new ideas.
- But sometimes things don't fit together as well as they should.

iD

- The original iD developer made controversial decisions when writing it.
- The Foundation took over development and paid developers.
- There is a review panel to review development if necessary.
- The review panel has never been asked to make a decision.

Route relations in Nominatim

- Name is meant to only be the name
- But for route relations it often isn't
- Nominatim simply ignores names of route relations as a result
- Search for “South Circular Road” and you won't find the one in London



Do we ever not want to give mappers free rein?

- OSM has let its mapping and tagging conventions evolve over time
- Sometimes it make sense to clean things up
- This has involved some massive things such as moving tags for multipolygons from the outer way onto the relation

[Tagging] Deprecation - waterway=riverbank vs water=river

Michael Patrick [geodesy99 at gmail.com](mailto:geodesy99@gmail.com)
Fri Feb 12 04:10:18 UTC 2021

- Previous message (by thread): [\[Tagging\] Deprecation - waterway=riverbank vs water=river](#)
- Next message (by thread): [\[Tagging\] Deprecation - waterway=riverbank vs water=river](#)
- Messages sorted by: [\[date\]](#) [\[thread\]](#) [\[subject\]](#) [\[author\]](#)

INRE: " Coders must adapt to business requirements not the other way round."
See <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BKorP55Aqvg>

Information Architecture is a two way street. Business requirements rarely acknowledge the technical constraints of the software environment, so they have to inform one another. And with a volunteer workforce, the coders don't 'have' to listen to anybody. Which is probably a feature, not a bug in OSM.

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URL: <<http://lists.openstreetmap.org/pipermail/tagging/attachments/20210211/2284455e/attachment.htm>>

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[More information about the Tagging mailing list](#)

Multilingual names in maps

- Some mapping products use names in multiple languages from Wikidata because there aren't enough of them in the OSM database
- When we incorporated the Maptiler OMT layer in our website this was seen as a quality control problem

Data consumers

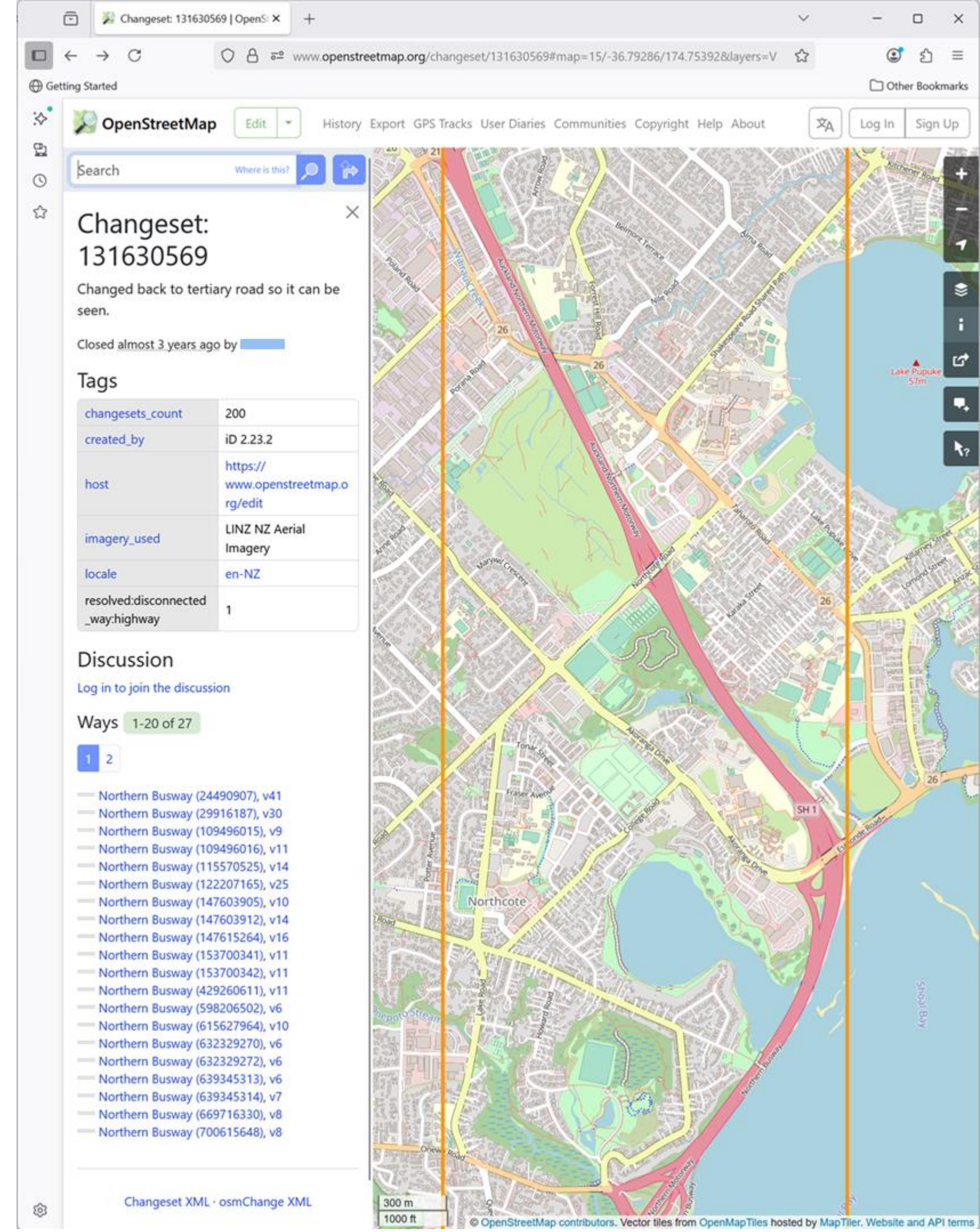
- Most data consumers should be free to take advantage of the database how they like
- But a few consumers hosted on the website are part of the map creation process

OSM-Carto

- Developers make their own choices what to render
- This makes sense for end-user maps, not as much as part of mappers' experience
- It can only take an objection from one maintainer to stop a change
- Some tools add tags supported by OSM-Carto alongside alternatives from the community

OSM-Carto

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- Some tools add tags supported by OSM-Carto alongside alternatives from the community
- Sometimes people tag for the renderer as a result



So, how do we go forwards?

- For applications on the front page, encourage cooperation
- Encourage cooperative software maintainers
- But still be responsive to their reasonable needs
- We shouldn't and can't afford to pay all or even most of our developers
- No one application should be too big to drop as a last resort
- Have alternatives for important tools
- Whatever we do needs community support from the bottom up

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<https://www.openstreetmap.org/user/Wynndale>